

hopelessly lonely. Igor's father was principal bass singer at St. Petersburg's Mariinsky Opera; his mother was a pianist who seemed to adopt a severe attitude to young Igor and his three brothers. The nearest he had to a true mother-figure was his German nurse, Bertha, who brought him up to speak her language fluently, besides the French spoken by the Russian upper classes.

Igor demonstrated a musical ear from an early age, made good progress with piano lessons, and was enthralled by what he saw and heard at the Mariinsky Theater, including the great ballet scores of Tchaikovsky. Yet he was far from a prodigy: he later admitted that his father's insistence that he should study law was not unreasonable, given the absence of exceptional early talent usually needed to pursue a musical career. While he was a reluctant law student, he took private lessons in composition with Rimsky-Korsakov, which was crucial for his development into one of the supreme composers of his generation.